

The Power ROUTE

The Chhattisgarh chief minister knows that utilising the state's huge coal reserves is the key to bringing investment and growth to one of India's poorest states

By Ambreesh Mishra

If it wasn't for frenetic industrial activity underway in the backwaters of Chhattisgarh, Chief Minister Raman Singh's dreams would sound utopian. But the clanging of metal and bright sparks coming out from a welder's torch at the third unit of the 1,620-mw Lanco Amarkantak power plant under construction just off the Korba-Champa highway are a clear pointer to changing times. Dandakaranya, in the state's south, may still be a Maoist stronghold but the coal-rich northern highlands of the state are emerging as the power hub of the country.

"If you're not in Chhattisgarh, you're missing big-time action," says K. Raja Gopal, Director and CEO of Delhi-based Lanco Amarkantak. The list of investors in the coal-bearing districts of Raigarh, Janjgir-Champa and Korba reads like the Who's Who of the country's power sector majors—Jindal Power, Essar and Adani, to name a few. Raman's policy is to leverage value from Chhattisgarh's coal reserves—estimated to be the largest in the country at 16 per cent. "So, the resource should be monetised to the hilt. We have to derive the maximum possible revenue to plough back for the



RAMAN AT THE INAUGURATION OF A POWER PLANT

The Raman EFFECT

65 MoUs

with IPPs to generate 56,000 MW power from India's largest coal reserves.

5 Power

plants to be commissioned over the next two years.

30,000 MW

additional capacity to be generated in the next seven years.

15,000 crore

rupees annual income by trading power can make the state revenue surplus.